

The American Heart Association Diet and Lifestyle Recommendations

A healthy diet and lifestyle are the keys to preventing and managing cardiovascular disease. It's not as hard as you may think. Remember, it's the overall pattern of your choices that counts. Make the simple steps below part of your life for long-term benefits to your health and your heart.

Use up at least as many calories as you take in.

- Start by knowing how many calories you should eat and drink to maintain your weight. Nutrition and calorie information on food labels is typically based on a 2,000-calorie-per-day diet. You may need fewer or more calories depending on several factors including age, gender, height, weight, level of physical activity and whether you are pregnant or breastfeeding.
- Aim for at least [150 minutes of moderate physical activity](#) or 75 minutes of vigorous physical activity (or an equal combination of both) each week. Ideally, your activity should be spread throughout the week.
- Increase the amount and intensity of your physical activity to burn more calories.

Regular physical activity can help you achieve and maintain a healthy weight, keep off weight that you lose and reach physical and cardiovascular fitness. If it's hard to schedule regular exercise, look for ways to build short bursts of activity into your daily routine such as parking farther away and taking the stairs instead of the elevator. Try incorporating muscle-strengthening activity at least twice a week. You can do these workouts separately from your cardio activity or add resistance to an existing workout.

Eat an overall healthy dietary pattern that includes:

- A wide variety of [vegetables and fruits](#)
- Whole grains and products made up mostly of [whole grains](#) rather than refined grains
- [Healthy sources of protein](#) (Shift from meat to plant sources like beans, peas, lentils and nuts, regularly consume fish and seafood, select low-fat or fat-free dairy products instead of full-fat dairy products and if you like meat, choose skinless and lean cuts, minimizing processed forms and portions)
- Sources of unsaturated fat such as non-tropical liquid plant oils in place of sources of saturated fat found in foods like coconut oil, butter and fatty meats.
- Whole foods and minimally [processed foods](#) instead of ultraprocessed foods
- Minimized intake of [added sugars](#) from beverages and foods
- Foods low in sodium and prepared with little or no [salt](#)
- If you don't drink alcohol, don't start and if you do, limit your intake.

Apply this guidance wherever food is prepared or consumed.

It is possible to follow a heart-healthy dietary pattern regardless of whether food is prepared at home, [ordered in a restaurant or online](#), or purchased as a prepared meal. Read the [Nutrition Facts](#) and [ingredient list](#) on packaged food labels to choose those with less sodium, added sugars and saturated fat. Look for the [Heart-Check mark](#) to find foods that have been certified by the American Heart Association as heart-healthy.

What is the Mediterranean Diet?

Year after year, the Mediterranean diet comes out on top in the U.S. News and World Report annual ranking of best diets. A panel of experts judges various eating plans and popular diets on criteria including how healthy they are, how well they work and how easy they are to follow.

The Mediterranean diet is also touted as one of the healthiest by many health organizations and dietitians. So, does it live up to its good reputation?

What is the Mediterranean diet?

“Mediterranean diet” is a generic term based on the traditional eating habits in the countries bordering the Mediterranean Sea. There’s not one standard Mediterranean diet. At least 16 countries border the Mediterranean. Eating styles vary among these countries and even among regions within each country because of differences in culture, ethnic background, religion, economy, geography and agricultural production. However, there are some common factors.

A Mediterranean-style diet typically includes:

- plenty of fruits, vegetables, bread and other grains, potatoes, beans, nuts and seeds;
- olive oil as a primary fat source; and
- dairy products, eggs, fish and poultry in low to moderate amounts.

Fish and poultry are more common than red meat in this diet. It also centers on minimally processed, plant-based foods. Wine may be consumed in low to moderate amounts, usually with meals. Fruit is a common dessert instead of sweets.

Does the American Heart Association recommend a Mediterranean-style diet?

Yes. A Mediterranean-style diet can help you achieve the American Heart Association’s recommendations for a [healthy dietary pattern](#) that:

- **emphasizes** vegetables, fruits, whole grains, beans and legumes;
- **includes** low-fat or fat-free dairy products, fish, poultry, non-tropical vegetable oils and nuts; and
- **limits** added sugars, sugary beverages, sodium, highly processed foods, refined carbohydrates, saturated fats, and fatty or processed meats.

This style of eating can play a big role in preventing heart disease and stroke and reducing risk factors such as obesity, diabetes, high cholesterol and high blood pressure. There is some evidence that a Mediterranean diet rich in virgin olive oil may help the body remove excess cholesterol from arteries and keep blood vessels open.

What you eat affects many aspects of your overall health, including [brain health](#). A healthy diet can improve your ability to think, remember and process information as you age.

In one study, the healthiest eaters at age 50 had a nearly 90% lower risk of dementia compared with those who had the least healthy diets. The Mediterranean and DASH diets have been proven to boost brain health as well as improve heart health.

What about other popular diets?

You may have heard about popular diets like paleo, ketogenic (or keto), Atkins, interval, zone and Whole30. Keep in mind, not all trendy diets meet the American Heart Association's science-based criteria for a healthy eating pattern. Some show dramatic but short-term results and are not heart-healthy.

DASH, or Dietary Approaches to Stop Hypertension, is another eating plan that aligns with the American Heart Association recommendations and has been proven to improve health. The DASH diet allows more dairy products and meat, while the Mediterranean diet includes regular use of olive oil.

A [plant-based, vegetarian or vegan diet](#) can also be a healthy way to eat.

The most important thing is to focus on the overall quality of your diet, rather than single nutrients or foods. Try to include more [nutrient-dense foods](#) such as vegetables, fruits, legumes and lean proteins. Limit foods that offer lots of calories but little nutritional value.

Healthy Recipes